“If I can help it, no one will touch you. But it means you will not be able to leave my sight.”

“For how long?” She remembered when he’d spoken of the Soviet army’s blind rage.

“We shall see, but likely a very long time.”

She visited the patients left behind in the sick bay, helping them to get out of bed to use the toilet, and providing them with water. If Reinhardt gave her an egg or a sausage, she shared it with them. Since most of the country’s rail tracks had been destroyed, no food supplies were shipped in, and all that was left were the rutabagas and potatoes from last year’s harvest. It was still early for the allotments to be producing. Many people wandered around with hungry ghost-like eyes.

Restless, she too wandered, staying clear of the main road as plenty of fighting was still going on in the Müglitz Valley. At night, she was mostly alone in the barracks, though there were a few Polish women on the ground floor, unsure of what to do and waiting for someone to tell them. She could hear shots around town, and the Panzer tanks still rumbled through, heading south; Rose wondered if there was still fighting in Prague.

During the day, she visited the places where she and André used to go: the forest, the old washhouse by the river, the allotments above the village. The factories were all shut; most of the foreign workers had fled. Down at the river, the meisters, whom Rose had only seen on the factory floor shouting about production quotas and threatening to dock pay, now tracked back and forth bringing files and papers from the offices to throw in the Müglitz River. There was neither coal nor wood to burn, so they relied on the water to swallow and hide their misdeeds. On the second day, the river became clogged with all those files, and the dam at the entrance to the town overflowed. She had heard that the Müglitz joins the Elbe, and she wondered if any of those papers might reach that far.

Rose had her own misdeed to throw in the river. She lifted the square paper she’d been carrying deep in her pocket for months. Unfolding it, she looked at the house André had drawn. *How many children do you want?* She could hear his voice as if he were standing next to her, whispering the words in her ears. She wondered if he had read the note she’d given him, and hoped with all her heart that he would forgive her for hurting him, and that he knew her true feelings, feelings that would never die. She realized